Module 2: Excel Formatting

Excel formatting is used to make data attractive, readable, professional, and easy to understand. In this module, students will learn how to format text, numbers, dates, apply conditional formatting, and prepare worksheets for printing.

1. Font, Border and Alignment

A. Font Formatting

Font formatting changes the appearance of text inside cells.

Common options available in the Home tab:

- Font Style: Change the font, such as Arial or Calibri.
- Font Size: Increase or decrease text size.
- Bold (Ctrl + B): Make text darker and thicker.
- Italic (Ctrl + I): Make text slanted.
- Underline (Ctrl + U): Add a line below text.
- Font Color: Change the text color.
- Fill Color: Change the background color of cells.

Example: Make the heading Student Marks Report bold, increase its font size to 16, and apply a background color.

B. Border Formatting

Borders add lines around cells to separate and organize data.

Common border options:

- Bottom Border
- Top Border
- Left Border
- Right Border
- All Borders
- Outside Borders
- Thick Outside Borders

Practical use: Apply All Borders to a student marksheet so that each student's information is clearly separated.

C. Alignment Formatting

Alignment controls the position of content inside a cell.

- Left Align: Aligns content to the left.
- Center Align: Places content in the center.
- Right Align: Aligns content to the right.
- Top Align: Positions content at the top.
- Middle Align: Positions content vertically in the middle.
- Bottom Align: Positions content at the bottom.
- Wrap Text: Displays long content on multiple lines within a cell.
- Merge & Center: Combines selected cells and centers the content across them.

Practical activity

Create the following table and format it professionally.

Student Name	**Course**	**Fees**
Rahul Patel	Excel	5,000
Priya Shah	Python	7,000
Amit Kumar	Web Development	10,000

Tasks:

1. Make the headings bold.
2. Apply a background color to the heading row.
3. Add all borders.
4. Center-align the headings.
5. Adjust column widths.
6. Apply Wrap Text wherever required.

2. Number and Date Formatting

Number formatting changes how values appear in cells without necessarily changing their underlying values.

A. Number Formatting

Common number formats include:

- General: Excel's default format.
- Number: Displays numeric values, with optional decimal places.
- Currency: Displays a currency symbol, such as ₹.
- Accounting: Aligns currency symbols and decimal points.
- Percentage: Displays a number as a percentage.

- Fraction: Displays values as fractions.
- Scientific: Displays numbers in scientific notation.
- Text: Treats entries as text.

Example:

Original value	**Format**	**Display**
2500	Number with 2 decimals	2,500.00
2500	Currency	₹2,500.00
0.75	Percentage	75%
5	Number with 2 decimals	5.00

Note: The displayed currency symbol and decimal style depend on the selected format and regional settings.

B. Date Formatting

Excel supports several date display formats.

Example date	**Format**	**Display**
29 October 2026	dd-mm-yyyy	29-10-2026
29 October 2026	dd/mm/yyyy	29/10/2026
29 October 2026	dd-mmm-yyyy	29-Oct-2026
29 October 2026	mmmm d, yyyy	October 29, 2026

How to apply number or date formatting

1. Select the required cells.
2. Open the Home tab.
3. Find the Number Format dropdown.
4. Select Number, Currency, Percentage, Date, or another suitable format.
5. For additional options, press Ctrl + 1 to open Format Cells.

Important: Formatting a cell as a date does not always convert text into a real Excel date. The underlying entry must be recognized as a date value.

Practical activity

Create an employee salary sheet with these columns:

Employee	Salary	Incentive	Joining Date
Rahul	25000	0.10	15-01-2025
Priya	30000	0.15	10-06-2024
Amit	22000	0.05	20-03-2026

Tasks:

- Format Salary as currency.
- Format Incentive as percentage.
- Format Joining Date as dd-mmm-yyyy.
- Display salary with two decimal places.

3. Custom Number Formats

Custom number formats allow users to control how numbers, dates, text, and other values are displayed.

They are especially useful when preparing professional reports, invoices, salary sheets, and business records.

How to create a custom number format

1. Select the cells.
2. Press Ctrl + 1.
3. Select the Number tab.
4. Select Custom.
5. Enter the required format in the Type box.
6. Click OK.

Common custom number formats

Custom format	Example display
00000	00125
₹#,##0	₹25,000
0.00	25.50
0%	75%
dd-mmm-yyyy	29-Oct-2026
0 "Units"	25 Units
0.0 "kg"	12.5 kg

+0;-0;0	+25, -10, 0

In these formats, quoted text such as "Units" is displayed as a label alongside the number.

Understanding zero placeholders

- 0 forces a digit to appear, including zeros where needed.
- # displays a digit only when required.
- ? reserves space for insignificant zeros, helping align values.

For example, applying 00000 to the number 125 displays 00125, while the underlying value remains 125.

Practical activity: Product inventory

Product	Quantity	Weight
Keyboard	25	1.2
Mouse	8	0.2
Monitor	12	4.5

Tasks:

1. Display Quantity using the format 000.
2. Display Weight using 0.0 "kg".
3. Display Quantity with the suffix " Units".
4. Apply a suitable date format to an additional Purchase Date column.

4. Conditional Formatting

Conditional Formatting automatically changes the appearance of cells when specified conditions are met.

For example, a teacher can highlight students scoring below 35 in red or students scoring 90 and above in green.

Types of Conditional Formatting

1. Highlight Cell Rules

Highlights cells based on conditions such as:

- Greater Than
- Less Than
- Between
- Equal To
- Text That Contains
- A Date Occurring
- Duplicate Values

2. Top/Bottom Rules

Highlights values such as the top 10 items, bottom 10 items, or values above or below average.

3. Data Bars

Displays bars inside cells to compare values visually.

4. Color Scales

Uses different colors to show high, medium, and low values.

5. Icon Sets

Displays arrows, traffic lights, or other icons according to values.

6. Formula-Based Formatting

Applies formatting when a custom formula evaluates to TRUE.

Practical example: Student results

Student	**Marks**
Rahul	92
Priya	28
Amit	65
Neha	35
Karan	18

Suppose the marks are in cells B2:B6.

To highlight marks below 35:

1. Select B2:B6.
2. Go to Home → Conditional Formatting.
3. Select Highlight Cells Rules → Less Than.
4. Enter 35.
5. Choose a red formatting style.
6. Click OK.

Now 28 and 18 will be highlighted in red.

Advanced example: Pass and fail status

Suppose marks are in column B and the passing threshold is 35.

Use a formula-based rule to highlight the entire student row:

=$B2<35

Select the data rows first, then create a Conditional Formatting rule using this formula. Choose a red fill.

For a green highlight for passing marks, use:

=$B2>=35

The formula assumes the first selected data row is row 2 and marks are stored in column B.

Practical activity

Create a sales performance report with at least 10 employees.

Tasks:

- Highlight sales below ₹10,000 in red.
- Highlight sales above ₹50,000 in green.
- Apply Data Bars to the sales column.
- Use a Color Scale for student marks.
- Identify duplicate employee IDs using Conditional Formatting.

5. Page Layout and Printing

Page Layout and Printing features help users prepare Excel worksheets for printing or exporting as PDFs.

A. Page Layout Settings

- Margins: Control the blank space around the printed content.
- Orientation: Select Portrait or Landscape.
- Size: Select the paper size, such as A4.
- Print Area: Choose which part of the worksheet to print.
- Breaks: Control where printed pages begin and end.
- Scale to Fit: Adjust worksheet scaling to fit the desired number of pages.
- Print Titles: Repeat selected rows or columns on multiple printed pages.
- Gridlines: Control whether worksheet gridlines appear in print settings.
- Headings: Control whether row numbers and column letters are printed.

B. Portrait vs. Landscape

Portrait

Vertical layout. Suitable for short reports and lists.

Horizontal layout. Suitable for wide marksheets and financial reports.

C. How to print an Excel worksheet

1. Open the workbook.
2. Go to Page Layout.
3. Set the paper size to A4.
4. Select Portrait or Landscape.
5. Adjust margins.
6. Set a Print Area if you only need part of the sheet.
7. Press Ctrl + P to open Print Preview.
8. Check page breaks and scaling.
9. Select the printer and click Print.

You can also select Microsoft Print to PDF or another available PDF printer to create a PDF file.

Important: Avoid scaling a large worksheet to one page if the text becomes too small to read. Use multiple pages when necessary.

Practical activity

Create a student marksheet with 20 students and prepare it for printing.

Tasks:

- Set paper size to A4.
- Select Landscape orientation.
- Set suitable margins.
- Apply Print Area to the marksheet.
- Check Print Preview.
- Export the worksheet as a PDF.

Module 2: Homework and Assessment

Practical homework checklist

- Format a student marksheet using fonts, borders, colors, and alignment.
- Apply Number, Currency, Percentage, and Date formats.

- Create three custom number formats and explain their output.
- Apply Conditional Formatting to highlight pass/fail marks.
- Use Data Bars or Color Scales to visualize marks or sales.
- Prepare a worksheet for A4 printing and export it as a PDF.